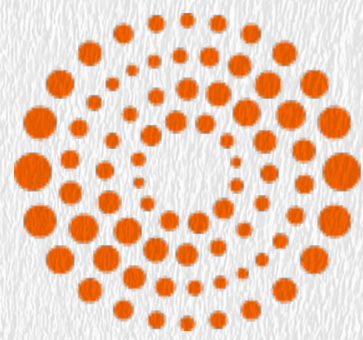




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THE HERITAGE of FLEET STREET

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On 14th June 1851, Paul Julius Reuter, a German-born immigrant, arrived in London from Aachen where he was running a news and stock price information service. He had been using telegraph cables and a fleet of carrier pigeons to bridge a gap between exchanges.

These innovative methods helped Reuter establish an enviable reputation for speed, accuracy and impartiality. Foreseeing the electrical telegraph revolution Reuter moved to London to set up his “Submarine Telegraph” office at No. 1 Royal Exchange Buildings in the City of London on 10th October 1851, ahead of the Dover-Calais cable, newly laid by the Submarine Telegraph Company, opening for business.

The Dover-Calais cable was the first operational undersea electrical telegraph cable and as the telegraph network spread around the world so did Reuters. Reuter soon extended his service to other European countries and expanded the content to include general and economic news. By 1858, Reuter was supplying most of the leading European newspapers with general news.

Reuter’s reputation for accuracy, speed and impartiality set his service aside from other telegram companies in the 1850s and 1860s. Reuter built a formidable brand; his clients and the public alike trusted him and his service.

Reuter’s foreign intelligence reports became a service that was indispensable to competing newspapers.

The influence of Reuters quickly spread beyond Europe as telecommunications facilities developed. During the 1860s Reuter established offices throughout the British Empire and by 1872 Reuters had agents located in the Far East. Julius Reuter’s motto was, fittingly, “follow the cable”. In 1863 he built and opened his own private telegraph line from Cork to Crookhaven in Ireland to gain five hours over his rivals by intercepting the Atlantic mail steamers some 80 miles further south-west.

‘Follow the cable’ went on to become Reuters’ guiding principle for using the latest technological methods in pursuit of being first with the news. From 1923 Reuters pioneered the use of radio to transmit news internationally.

Despite Reuters reaching outer space the company was in a financial blackhole. However, Reuters fortunes were to skyrocket by following the cable into the age of computers and pioneering the use of computers to transmit information internationally. Starting with the launch of the Stockmaster service in 1964, it became clear that the company’s business future would depend on computer services. In 1967 Reuters Monitor Screen was launched - a revolutionary computerised product initially used for the retrieval of financial data and destined to transform Reuters.

Then, in 1973, Reuters Monitor Money Rates Service was launched, an electronic marketplace for Foreign Exchange. It enabled traders to display up-to-date rates for currencies on screens, providing much-needed real-time market information after the dismantling of the Bretton Woods agreement and the abandonment of fixed exchange rates by major western industrialized countries.

The Reuter Monitor expanded rapidly to carry general news as well as the latest financial updates. In 1981 the Reuter Monitor Dealing Service started, marking a new phase in the development of the company’s computerized services. After a dramatic increase in profitability between 1980-1984, Reuters was floated as a public company. However, Reuters’ journalistic independence was safeguarded by the Trust Principles adopted during a restructure in 1941. These principles committed Reuters to independence, integrity and freedom from bias in the gathering and dissemination of news and information.

In 1985 Reuters became a multimedia news agency after acquiring a majority shareholding in Visnews, a video company that would become Reuters Television in 1994, and establishing Reuters Pictures Service.

The Thomson Corporation and Reuters Group PLC combined to form Thomson Reuters in 2008. Reuters had a new name, but the same Trust Principles safeguarded its independence. Since the merge ‘follow the cable’ has continued to be Reuters’ guiding principle; in 2022 it acquired a small real time financial news service powered by artificial intelligence called PLX AI. Reuters continues to be first with the news too. In 2022 Reuters was first to report that Vladimir Putin had authorized a ‘special military operation’ against Ukraine on the morning of 24th February.